

EXPLORING TATTOO TRADITIONS AMONG WOMEN OF INDIGENOUS HINDU TRIBES IN SINDH

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Abstract:

“Dard nahi hota (It doesn't hurt).”

That's what they told us casually, as the needle pierced skin. A thread still looped through the hole, the ink made from burnt iron scraped and mixed with water. A seven-year-old girl sat still, her eyes dry, her expression unbothered.

The pain, it seemed, had long been stitched out of the process. But for us, as “outsiders”, the curiosity remained: the what's, why's, how's, and who's.

Our search began in Karachi, when we saw a woman in the crowd who refused to blur into it, her face and hands were marked with blackish designs that felt ancient, deliberate. Like the pictures of old drawings in our history course books. The markings, how they looked, felt similar. Even the shade of black was reminiscent of what we would see in those images. That encounter became a doorway. We followed it to Mithi, Tharparkar, Sindh, where over three days, we spoke with members of the *Meghwar* and *Kolhi* communities, women, girls, mothers, and elders, asking questions, listening, and learning. We were told these markings are called *tajwas*, tribal tattoos inked onto girls as young as six, before marriageable age around 13. Each symbol held something: protection, identity, memory, medicine, sometimes beauty for beauty's sake.

While one of the very few academic articles we could find stated that the practice is fading, our fieldwork suggested otherwise. The practice hasn't disappeared; it has simply stopped announcing itself. In an age where culture is often measured by a mediated form of visibility, circulation in media, inclusion in digital archives, recognition in urban spaces, or incorporation into commodity culture, *tajwas* exist in a different register. While they are made to be seen, their visibility is intimate and local rather than mass-produced or publicly curated. They live in bodies, in memory, in the quiet conviction of a seven-year-old girl who does not flinch. Through this study, we explore this indigenous practice, we question and discuss the notions of tradition, beauty, love among other, and we are reminded that not all practices fade—some simply retreat, carried forward in places where few are looking, waiting not to be explained, but understood.

Introduction:

Tattoos are generally frowned upon in the Islamic Republic of Pakistan, where they remain relatively uncommon, though they are gradually gaining acceptance among some segments of society (Shaikh, 2022). Even in urban areas, where Western influences have fostered greater acceptance, tattoos continue to be met with hesitation and significant stigma, especially when seen on women (Broussard & Harton, 2017), a reality not just in Pakistan but globally. However, the tribal women of Sindh present a striking contrast. Women from tribes such as Kolhi, Meghwar, Rabari, and others adorn their arms, necks, faces, and bodies with tattoos, maintaining a deeply rooted cultural tradition.

This contrast raises compelling questions: How (and possibly why) do these women, primarily farmers living in remote areas with minimal exposure to global trends or digital influences, maintain such a strong tattooing tradition? In a world where tattoos are often seen as a masculine form of self-expression, why are they a dominantly female practice in these tribes? What kind of meaning making, if any, is involved in tattooing? What stories do they tell and for whom? Is getting a tattoo a celebrated rite of passage, is it simply an everyday practice, or is it an outright form of denial to the difference of ritual and everyday life? Who holds the needle—must the tattoo artist be someone special, or can anyone ink a design at any time? What transformations have occurred in this practice over time? How have these questions evolved as the tradition adapts to external influences, that is, if it does? How has tattooing been shaped by the integration of outside cultural traditions?

This research explores the cultural significance, traditions, and symbolism of these tattoos, focusing on their exclusivity to women, the process of their creation, and their role within the community. Rather than viewing tradition as static, this research examines the evolving nature of tattooing and its connection to changing perceptions of self, community, religiosity, and identity. By documenting an indigenous practice commonly perceived at risk of fading due to modernization and socio-cultural shifts, this study enhances understanding and awareness of the tattoo traditions among the tribes of Sindh. It records historical meanings, artistic transformations, and the lived experiences of Sindhi tribal women, addressing their underrepresentation in academic and media narratives.

While body art and tattooing have been widely studied in global contexts, there remains a significant gap in research on indigenous tattooing traditions within Pakistan. Academic and media narratives often marginalize or overlook these communities, resulting in a lack of documentation and critical engagement with their cultural practices. Most existing literature focuses on urban, or Western-influenced tattoo cultures, leaving indigenous, gendered, and rural practices underrepresented.

This research is significant because it centres on the cultural, social, and symbolic meanings of tattooing among women of indigenous Hindu tribes such as the Kolhi, and Meghwar. It examines tattooing not just as a form of aesthetic expression but as an embodied tradition tied to identity, memory, love and belonging.

Literature Review:

Origins of the Indigenous Hindu Tribes

Different tribal groups trace their origins to various parts of South Asia, with most being located in Rajasthan, Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Bikaner, Bahawalpur, Tharparkar, and the lower regions of Sindh. Today, these tribes are found along the borders of Pakistan and India (particularly between Sindh, Bahawalpur, Rajasthan, and Gujarat) and, in some cases, as far as Nepal. These indigenous communities, largely composed of lower-caste Hindus, have histories rooted in internal migrations, socio-political transformations, and cultural exchanges across the region. Historical records, oral traditions, and colonial-era writings provide insight into their long-standing presence, their connections with neighboring regions, and the impact of historical events on their socio-economic structures.

Historically, Sindh's boundaries were not rigidly defined due to the absence of maps, survey instruments, or border stones. As a result, the territorial limits of Sindh were often arbitrarily determined, leading to frequent border disputes with neighboring regions. In the early 19th century, rulers of Rajasthan and Bahawalpur contested borders with the Talpurs of Sindh (Panhwar, 1989). This historical fluidity meant that indigenous communities frequently moved between these regions without the constraints of modern national borders. Consequently, the presence of these tribes in Sindh, Rajasthan, and Bahawalpur cannot be attributed to recent migration; rather, these groups have continuously inhabited and interacted across these areas for centuries.

Sindh's indigenous tribes are mentioned in some of the earliest recorded texts, including the Ramayana and Mahabharata. The Ramayana refers to the people of Thar, Sindh, and the Indian desert as Maru, while the Mahabharata identifies them as Abhiras (inhabitants of southern Thar and the southwestern Indian desert) and Kukura (southern Thar and the adjoining Indian desert). Additionally, the region now known as Kutch was historically referred to as Kaccha, with its people known as Paraskara (Panhwar n.d.). These references indicate that indigenous communities have been present in the region for millennia, engaging with broader South Asian cultural and political spheres.

During the medieval period, one of the earliest ruling tribes in the region, the Soomras (1024–1351 CE), played a crucial role in shaping Sindh's tribal composition, forming alliances and facilitating internal migration. The Soomras were believed to be an indigenous Rajput clan (Panhwar, n.d.). While some recent historians claim that they originated from Iraq or were associated with the Qarmati community, others dismiss these narratives as fabricated. Oral traditions and Kutchi ballads suggest that the Kutchis migrated to Sindh to protect the ladies of the Soomra royal family, suggesting historical connections between Sindh, Rajasthan, and Gujarat (Panhwar, n.d.). However, Panhwar – in his book *An Illustrated Historical Atlas of Soomra Kingdom of Sindh* – argues against such migration theories, stating that all these theories were “unknown to the past historians” (p. 26). The Soomras were originally a Hindu tribe local to Sindh. Some of them, after the Arab conquest of Sindh, converted to the Ismaili sect of Islam but retained mixed practices. Hence, contrary to general belief, “there has been

no migration of these tribes to the surrounding areas”; the tribes have always been here (Panhwar, p. 26). But how, when, and why did these stories and rumors of migration arise, and why are these tribes commonly misidentified as having ‘migrated’ and ‘settled’ in a land not native to them?

Panhwar reveals further in the book that following the Mughal invasion, indigenous Muslim tribes faced systemic discrimination, similar to non-Muslims, leading them to seek external affiliations for legitimacy and survival. The Soomras began identifying as Sumerians, the Sammas linked themselves to Persian ancestry, and the Kalhoras claimed descent from the Abbasid Caliphate. Similarly, warrior tribes from the desert regions of Sindh, Kutch, Gujarat, and Uttar Pradesh branded themselves as Rajputs. These associations demonstrate how colonial and post-colonial identity politics reshaped indigenous self-perceptions.

Religion also played a role in further isolating certain tribes. When Sindhi Brahman priests declared cows as sacred, the consumption of beef was banned among Hindus. However, lower-caste Hindu communities in Tharparkar, such as the Bhils, Meghwars, and Kolhis, continued to eat beef due to their reliance on livestock in such a non-irrigated arid area with low rainfall. Their non-compliance led to their ostracization as “untouchables” within Hindu society. Post-Partition, these communities faced continued marginalization, now from both Hindus and Muslims—regarded as outcasts by the former and non-Muslim minorities by the latter.

In *Castes of Mind*, Nicholas Dirks argues that the British colonial administration did not merely record existing caste identities but actively produced and fixed them, turning fluid and context-dependent ways of life into rigid, eternal categories. Each caste was assigned a singular trait or occupation—such as agriculture—and was thereafter officially recognized as only that, erasing the multiplicity and changeability of social identities (p. 181). By embedding these categorizations into administrative records and governance, the British made caste a permanent historical fact rather than a shifting social practice. The role of territory and location in shaping caste was similarly recast, diminished to the point of near erasure (p. 78). Under this system, some caste groups adapted, while others resisted. Those who resisted were criminalized through measures such as the Criminal Tribes Act of 1871. One example is the Koli tribe of western India, described in English, Marathi, and Persian sources from the 17th and 18th centuries, which the British reclassified as a “criminal tribe” due to its armed resistance against state laws (Vivekanand, 2016). Other tribes, including the Bhils and Grasias, faced similar branding, which led to persecution and displacement, pushing many into Sindh and contributing to the emergence of mixed tribal populations in the region.

The 19th and early 20th centuries witnessed various indigenous revolts against British rule and feudal oppression. The Koli Revolt (1859), the Bheel Rebellion (1822–1857), and the First Freedom Struggle (1856–57) exemplify tribal resistance across western India and Sindh. Many of these movements were violently suppressed, causing the displacement of indigenous populations, including the Kolhis, who migrated extensively within Sindh (Mohyuddin, 2014). These events reshaped tribal socio-economic structures, forcing communities to transition from traditional hunting and pastoral lifestyles to sharecropping and animal husbandry (Hussain, 2015).

Despite historical displacements and socio-economic changes, indigenous tribes in Sindh have preserved their cultural heritage through oral traditions. The Madadev Koli tribe of Maharashtra, for example, has played a crucial role in transmitting traditional knowledge through storytelling, dance, and rituals (Tandfonline, 1943). Similar practices can be observed among Sindh's indigenous communities, where tattooing, folk songs, and religious customs continue to serve as markers of identity. However, the decline of these traditions due to modernization and migration underscores the need for further ethnographic studies to document and preserve indigenous knowledge systems.

Origins and Cultural Significance of Tattoo Traditions

Tattoos are said to have a long history globally, with designs drawn around the world serving various purposes. Bianchi (1996), as quoted by Erick Edward Mgema (2023, pg.132), argues that the first evidence of tattooing was discovered in 1901 when the "Iceman" mummy was unearthed on the Italian-Austrian border, with tattoos carbon-dated to 5,300 years ago. Similarly, Mgema mentions historical traces of tattoos found in places like Greece, Persia, Sudan, China, Japan, and the Polynesian Islands (2023).

The discourse on indigenous body modification in South Asia has often been shaped by colonial and orientalist perspectives. One such example is Kedarnath Basu's (1892) article published in the *Science* journal, where he describes tattooing among Indian natives as a "savage" practice that disfigures the body. Basu argues that tattooing is absent from Sanskrit texts, at least to his knowledge, and hypothesizes that the practice was introduced to India through cultural contact with Burma. His work exemplifies the Eurocentric and hierarchical lens through which indigenous customs were often judged during the late 19th century. While the *Science* journal is a reputable publication, Basu's analysis lacks ethnographic rigor and is embedded in the prejudices of his time. His claim that tattooing was borrowed from Burma disregards the possibility of long-standing indigenous tattooing traditions across various Indian communities. Moreover, his deprecatory characterization of tattooed individuals as "savages" reflects a broader colonial discourse that sought to pathologize non-Western aesthetic and cultural expressions. This article serves as a counterpoint in contemporary research that seeks to challenge such misconceptions.

A.W. Buckland (1888) argues that tattooing customs observed in India, Japan, Egypt, New Guinea, New Zealand, Alaska, Greenland, and America share similarities in their designs, leading him to conclude that they all derived this custom from a common source. However, the book "History and Epidemiology of Tattoos" (2017, pg. 4-7) describes the diverse uses of tattoos among different regions within India, highlighting that various tribes, such as the Bhils, Santhals, Kanbis, and Warlis, use tattoos for beautification. Many women tattoo their foreheads and cheeks with peepal tree designs, which hold religious significance in Hinduism. In contrast, Rabari women also use tattoos for beautification, placing small marks on their throats, chins, arms, and hands. Among the Santhals, girls receive tattoos upon reaching puberty, believed to provide strength for motherhood and life challenges. Payel Ghosh (2020) further explores the Santhals, specifically the tattoos known as "Khuda," which are primarily worn by women and serve as markers of identity and social status. The specific designs, materials, and

rituals associated with Santhal tattooing further illustrate the complexity and cultural significance of the practice. Additionally, Ghosh cites the example of the Singpho tribe, where tattoos on specific body parts signify marital status, and the Konyak “head-hunters” who display their courage through tattoos. This contrasts with the historical use of tattoos to mark individuals with “disrespect and taboos” in Western societies, such as prisoners or those deemed “neuropsychiatric disables”.

Conversely, the Apatani tribe of Arunachal Pradesh tattoos their women to make them less attractive to rival tribes that seek to abduct pretty girls. The Malagasy-Nias-Dravidian tribes of the Malabar Coast use tattoos for medicinal purposes. In the Naga tribe, facial tattoos are commonly linked to identity and belonging, while Baiga women receive tattoos for sexual provocation at puberty. In Tamil Nadu, certain tribes practice “kollan” tattooing to protect against evil spirits until death (2017). These findings are also validated by Kanchan Paul (2019) whose master's dissertation explores the cultural significance of tattoos among various Indian tribes, focusing mainly on the Baiga tribe of Central India. Apart from the mentioned tribes, he also explores a few more tribes’ distinct tattooing practices. For instance, the Mer women tattoo their necks as an act of religious devotion, and the Kothari women use tattoos to protect their marriages from the evil eye. Among the Gond tribe, tattoos enhance one’s appearance with delicate patterns, while the Toda tribe engraves embroidery designs onto their skin. The Kutia Kondh tribe believes tattoos help recognize each other in the afterlife, whereas the Konyaks of Nagaland express their battlefield expertise and headcount through tattoos, and the Singpho tribe marks marital relationships through body art.

These detailed literary works on tattoos disproves Buckland's conjecture that tattoos around the world are similar in purpose and design, revealing instead that tribes within India have varying tattoos with distinct meanings and symbolism.

Paul (2019) also highlights a perspective on tattoos as a form of dowry, stating that “the tattoos are treated as the best dowry which a bride brought with her during marriage.” This cultural significance is also evident in the Kacchi Kolhi tribe of Sindh, Pakistan, where, according to an article published in Dawn News, Pakistan by Khalid Kumbhar (2023), “...if there is no tattoo on the body of a bride, the in-laws criticize her and call her a camel. It also shows that her parents are very poor.” Paul (2019) further traces the origins of Godna culture to Hindu mythology. One myth recounts that Parvati, the consort of Lord Shiva, ordered tribal women to mark themselves with specific symbols after a tribal god mistook her for a mortal and touched her. Another story suggests that Yamaraj, confused about the gender of the dead, sent his son and daughter-in-law with tattoos to guide humanity, establishing a tradition that continues today (Paul, 2019). This study details tattooing practices, including tools, techniques, and symbolic meanings, while examining how modernization has impacted this cultural heritage.

In another similar study, Kumar and Chadhar (2019) provide a detailed case study on the Baiga tribe of Madhya Pradesh, known for their forest-based economy and distinctive tattoo traditions. The authors explain that, like other Indian tribes, the Baiga attach their tattoo markings to signify religious beliefs, health practices, social status, wealth, and as decorative

ornaments. However, an aspect unique to the Baiga tribe is their use of tattoos as a means of sexual expression. Citing Ember et al., the authors discuss how some societies emphasize body decoration for women, while others focus on men, though the reasons behind these differences remain unclear. Among the Baiga, women use body art to draw attention to erogenous zones. For example, a tattoo placed just above the buttocks symbolizes "the gate" (p. 34). Similarly, a peacock tattoo is inked on a girl's breasts only after she reaches adolescence, while another design, the basket, is also tattooed on the female breast, symbolizing attraction for male partners (p. 34).

Outside India, the indigenous Filipino tattooing tradition known as Batok was extensively studied by Cabalquinto et al. (2022). Their research analyzed the significance of Batok tattoos among Filipino individuals through interviews and video observations. They noted that in pre-colonial Philippines, women received Batok tattoos after their first period, while men earned them as proof of courage and achievement. Traditionally, a ceremony involving close family and community members would accompany the tattooing process. Their research highlighted that the communal practice of Batok is deeply rooted in the everyday lives of indigenous people in the Philippines. This practice underscores the balance of doing, being, becoming, and belonging, which is essential for achieving optimal health. However, the authors further note that over time, "the practice of Batok has faded due to colonialism and imperialism in the Philippines, leading to its stigmatization" (Cabalquinto et al., 2022, pg 13).

Yujie Peng (2016) studied tattoo practices among the Baka people of southern Cameroon, identifying two types of tattoos: "tele," primarily for women and considered fashionable (nyanga), and "ma na waiya," reserved for men and associated with hunting. She found that the most common placements for women's "tele" tattoos were on their cheeks, forehead, and around the mouth, mirroring patterns observed among men. The tattooing process was conducted casually, without expecting payment or gifts. Baka women used razors to carve the skin and applied soot from lamps as pigment (Peng, 2016).

Shuaib Shadiat Olapeju (2020) explored body arts, including tattoos, body painting, facial markings, tooth fillings, and elaborate hairstyles across the African continent. He noted that in North Africa and Asia, tattoos were largely feminine and associated with fertility. In Nigerian culture, facial markings signified beauty, social ranking, self-identity, and ethnic affiliation. He cited Negri (1976, pg 129), who observed that Yoruba permanent facial marks served as differentiators for identifying families and tribes while also being used as geometric patterns on women's bodies to symbolize beauty and fertility (Olapeju, 2020).

Dion Kaszas (2018) examined tattoo traditions among the Ainu, indigenous people of northern Japan, where tattooing was exclusively practiced by women. Tattoos were placed on the lips, forearms, and hands, believed to ward off evil spirits until women reunited with their ancestors in the afterlife. The tattooing process involved using an obsidian knife to carve the skin, followed by rubbing pigment over the cuts (Kaszas, 2018).

Tanmoy Baghira (2013) discusses the cultural, social, and political meanings of tattoos across various cultures and subcultures. He explains how tattoos have historically served as tools for

social control, particularly in Roman and German history, and highlights their significance in indigenous cultures such as those in Polynesia, West Africa, and the Philippines. According to Baghira, tattoos have been used to signify criminality and belonging, as well as markers of masculinity and power dynamics. The paper also critically engages with the political dimensions of body modification practices, particularly regarding gender roles in tattooing and scarification.

Baghira cites Gustafson's essay, which identifies three types of tattoos in Roman tradition: one describing the crime of the tattoo-bearer, another naming the emperor under whose rule the crime was committed, and the third detailing the punishment given to the criminal. This tradition, seen as an aesthetic practice in some cultures, was also used as a mechanism of social control in the Holocaust and earlier in the Roman Empire, where, as Baghira states, "...tattoo being engraved into the body takes an active part in the political field of the signification process" (2013, pg. 301).

A study by Mooventhan et al. (2016) explored the cultural and health significance of traditional tattooing among tribal communities in Chhattisgarh, India. The process involves cleaning the designated body part and drawing the predetermined design, typically done by the Godharins. Three or four needles are tied together, dipped in Kajal (ink), and used to pierce the skin, often drawing blood. Turmeric powder and Ramtila (*Guizotia abyssinica*) oil are then applied to prevent infection. Traditional tattooing is believed to provide health benefits, such as alleviating digestive and joint issues, serving as a form of acupressure treatment, and protecting against paranormal activities (Mooventhan et al., 2016).

Tattooing Practices Among Indigenous Women in Sindh

The study of indigenous tattooing practices in Sindh, Pakistan, remains limited due to a lack of extensive scholarly research. Existing narratives provide only surface-level insights into the cultural meanings behind the practice. Eva Zu Beck (2022) documents the Kachi Kolhi tribe's facial tattoos in her travelogue on YouTube titled *The Tribal Women Who Tattoo Their Faces* (in Pakistan), offering an accessible introduction to their traditions. A slightly more in-depth examination – though still not scholarly research – comes from Khalid Kumbhar's article *Skin Deep: Sindh's Indigenous Tattoo Culture at Risk of Fading Away* (2023) in *Dawn*, where he, along with anthropologist Dr. Wassan, explores tattooing among Hindu tribe of the Kacchi Kolhi. These tattoos hold cultural, religious, and symbolic significance, marking identity, marital status, and life milestones. However, Kumbhar (2023) notes that the tradition is fading, particularly among younger women from affluent families, due to increasing integration with Muslim communities that do not practice tattooing. This decline reflects broader tensions between globalization and cultural preservation. While Tyler Cowen (2002) argues that globalization fosters both internal and external diversity, Sindh's case suggests otherwise, as social and religious pressures drive cultural homogenization. Without intervention, this rich aspect of Sindh's intangible heritage may soon disappear.

This literature review identifies several common themes in tattooing among women across the globe; however, there remains a notable gap in the study of the women of Sindh-Hindu tribes

in Pakistan. The two sources, Beck's observational travelogue and Kumbhar's ethnographic article, are the only substantive materials that were found online regarding indigenous tattooing traditions in Pakistan. The scarcity of academic literature on the subject is a significant gap in research. Scholarly discourse lacks documentation of Sindh's tattooing traditions, unlike other regions, forcing reliance on limited sources and highlighting the need for comprehensive ethnographic studies. The absence of research on tribal tattoo traditions in Pakistan raises concerns about the erosion of unique practices due to neglect. This research aims to address this gap by investigating the tattooing procedures, cultural significance, and historical context of tattoo traditions in Sindh to document this important cultural tradition. We also aim to study how this tradition has changed in the modern era to facilitate interaction with urban spaces.

Approach:

Our inquiry into the tattooing traditions of indigenous Hindu women in Sindh unfolded through an ethnographic approach rooted in attentiveness, and deep listening. Carried out in and around Mithi, Tharparkar, a region where Hindu tribal communities like the Kolhi and Meghwar maintain longstanding cultural practices, this study emerged through narrative encounters rather than strict protocols.

Instead of following a rigid sampling strategy, we relied on relationships and our contacts. Women and girls who were willing to speak with us, tattooed or not, became our interlocutors. Some were eager to share the meanings etched into their skin; others spoke of silence, hesitation, or departure from the practice.

Our field visit consisted of multiple methods: long-form conversations, group dialogues, everyday observations, and audiovisual documentation. Focus group discussions offered a collective space for women to reflect, affirm, and occasionally contest each other's memories and narratives. These were held in three distinct sites: Dharar and Sattaar villages, both within Kolhi communities, and a temple gathering in Mithi city with the Meghwar women. In each group, around 17 to 25 women participated.

Alongside these gatherings, we spent time with individuals, five married women and two adolescent girls, whose one-on-one interviews allowed us to listen personal narratives on a slower pace. These stories gave us a deeper look: the sting of the needle, the whispered encouragement of a mother or aunt, the reasons some chose not to mark their skin at all.

Throughout, our documentation was very dialogic. Field notes were made on gestures, hesitations, and emotions observed by us. Our video and audio recordings were handled with care, intended not just as data but as part of an ongoing visual ethnography, a documentary.

In returning to our notes, transcripts, and recordings, we listened again, this time with an ear toward patterns and dissonances. Themes surfaced through repeated readings and were allowed to grow organically. The coding process, if it can be called that, was more a gathering of threads than a dissection. These threads, beauty, pain, memory, belonging, resistance, were then placed in conversation with existing anthropological writings to ask questions like: what do these

women's voices add, shift, or unsettle in how we understand tattooing, embodiment, and cultural inheritance?

Discussion:

Our team, consisting of 4 members, boarded a bus from Karachi on 21st June 2025, at 4:00 AM in the morning. The journey was expected to last around six hours, with no scheduled stops. Every once in a while, however, the bus would halt briefly, no longer than 30 seconds, to allow additional passengers to board. This continued even after all seats had been occupied, with new passengers paying half fare to travel standing, holding onto whatever support they could find. Around 11:00 AM, tired and motion-sick, we stepped down at the bus stand of Mithi, Tharparkar: our ethnographic field site. By 12:30 PM, following a brief round of introductions and conversations with our interlocutors, we had departed to begin fieldwork in Dharar and Sattar villages, two settlements home to over 50 women and their families belonging to the Kolhi community. Over the next 3 days, we spent time with women of the Kolhi community, talking to them, listening to them sing wedding *geets* (songs), bonding through the fun yet challenging task of trying to overcome the linguistic differences, conducting focus group discussions on their perspectives of tattoos, and finally having detailed semi-structured interviews with a selected number of women.

Both these small villages were situated on barren lands, sand, and dried tree roots all around. But the browns and fading yellows of nature were balanced out by the reds, blues, greens, and purples of the women's vibrant traditional dresses. Children, many of whom were half-clothed and barefoot, ran around the tiny huts that seemed too small to accommodate families of their size. There were only a couple of men around, presumably gone to work. The women were hospitable, offering water, laying *daris* (handwoven rugs) and *charpais* (woven beds) for us to sit on. Most of them were very eager to talk, some more reserved, choosing not to participate as eagerly. Interestingly, when our cameraperson brought out his equipment (with their consent), a subtle hint of discomfort hanged in the air: women drawing their *ghoonghats* (veils) over their faces, some subtly shifting away from the lens—a quiet sign speaking of reluctance.

This discussion is based on our conversations with community members, combined with our own observations, thoughts and things we witnessed around the place. This does not imply that exactly similar practices are followed by the people of these communities throughout the world. A lot of practices, as backed by several studies, tend to mix with local norms and may take on new forms, depending on the region in which a community resides.

We found the whole process of exploring subject of this study, which was to explore the tribal tattoo tradition, far more complex for us than we had anticipated, mainly because the lack of academic literature on the topic within Pakistan's context left us unsure about what to expect; we didn't know if we should be focusing on the meanings (or if we should even assume there were any in the first place), interpretations, symbolism, or if we should just go with the flow and take in whatever narratives everyone had to offer. The Kolhi women we met called 'tattoo' in their local language Daharki—a dialect of Sindhi—a "*tajwa*". Derived from the Sindhi word *tubka*, they said it meant stitching in one's skin with a needle. According to them, young

unmarried Kolhi girls typically get their first *tajwa* around the age of 6, though there is no restriction if someone wishes to get one earlier. The average age of marriage for them is between 13 and 15, after which they rarely get a new *tajwa*. This makes the period of 7 to 9 years between a girl's first *tajwa* and her marriage the most common, and culturally significant, time for receiving these tattoos. Only the women of the tribe had these *tajwas*. They say that tattoos on men are considered much like *churiyan* (bangles)—they are seen as a rather feminine practice, an item of adornment. While some men do get their names tattooed on their forearms, the practice is not referred to as *tajwa*, even though the process is the same.

Tattoo-Making Process of the Kolhi Community:

According to the Kolhi women's demonstration to us, the process of tribal tattoo making begins by heating a *tawa* (used to make flatbread) on the stove. Once it is hot enough, the black layer that forms on the bottom from the heat is scraped off in a steel utensil using a spoon or knife. This layer comes off as a fine powder.

Water, oil, or ghee is then mixed into the powder to create a paste that is used as ink. Once the ink is cooled down and ready, a matchstick is used to draw the symbols on the part of the body where the person wants the *tajwa*.

After the design is drawn, a needle (typically one used for handicrafts, according to the community) is used. When the process was demonstrated to us, the needle still had thread in it, as if someone had just been sewing. The needle is used immediately, without sanitizing, and is poked repeatedly over the sketched design until the black ink is embedded into the skin. The process is very quick, usually lasting around 5 minutes of work.

According to the Kolhi women, the best time to get a *tajwa* is during the winters, between February to April, as the skin heals quickly during the cold days. A *tajwa* normally takes up to 3 days to heal, during which the skin may swell, burn, and feel somewhat painful, though the discomfort rarely bothers the women, who are often excited about the newly formed body mark. To an outsider, it may look painful and unsafe, but the young local girls (on whom the process was demonstrated) showed no visible reaction to the pain.

Tajwas as Markers of Beauty:

Tribal tattoo traditions have existed for millennia, becoming symbols of identity and belonging for some communities; for others, they serve medicinal, religious, sexual, or symbolic purposes tied to power. Among the Kolhi women, *tajwas* are primarily about *shoq* — personal interest or hobby — and beautification. They inherit this interest by watching their mothers, grandmothers, and aunts adorn themselves and each other with tattoos. Most women in the tribe take part in the tradition, and those who do not are few—often resisting significant peer pressure. In our conversations during focus groups at Kohli Colony, we met with only three women who chose not to tattoo themselves, who chose to not get *tajwas* because they did not want to go through the painful tattooing process. Their discomfort was evident, though — they sat at the back of the group. When they spoke, laughing about the pain other women go through during the tattoo-making process, they faced scornful looks from other interview participants.

They also refused to be interviewed later for one-on-one interviews, leaving in the middle of the focus group.

Within the community, tattoos are considered a marker of beauty. A woman with tattoos is not only seen as more attractive by others but also feels more beautiful herself. If a woman does not have tattoos, she may be perceived as less desirable for marriage by both men and other women in the tribe.

But what exactly does ‘beauty’ entail, especially for one who belongs to the Kolhi community? This was a question that we asked ourselves and our interviewees when all of them brought up the idea of beauty as one of the main reasons to get a *tajwa*. For many, the *tajwa* was the only way through which beauty could be attained — Nano, one of our interview participants, said, “If she (any woman) has a *tajwa*, she is beautiful ... otherwise, she is not. She is just not.” Here, definitively connecting *tajwas* with the notion of beauty created a very binary understanding of beauty — either you have a *tajwa* and are beautiful, or you do not have one and you are not.

In this conversation, we brought up the idea of this beauty being connected to marriage — in the Baiga tribe in India, for example, “a tribal girl should tattoo her body prior to marriage ... satisfying aesthetic needs, body decoration or adornment” (Chadhar, 2019, 33). However, this idea did not resonate with the Kohli women we spoke with — these women were adamant that a marriage is not stopped or postponed if a girl does not have a *tajwa*. However, it significantly adds to her beauty.

But what does beauty even mean in a context such as this one?

When we asked our participants what beauty meant, they pointed towards nature. “Cows are beautiful, my children are beautiful, a person with a good heart is beautiful, my husband is beautiful,” said an elderly grandmother. The word they used for beautiful — *sutho* — is the same word that is used to refer to ‘good’. In this understanding, good and beautiful are often equated with each other. But when we speak of the *tajwa*, the use of the *tajwa* only by women as a tool for beautification implies that beauty means different things for men and women. When we pointed this out to our participants, they were quick to dismiss our binary understanding of beauty. “The *tajwa* is important to look beautiful, but you also have to be *sutho* (good/beautiful) inside. The woman has to do *sutho* things, she must be *sutho* in her words...not only the *tajwa* and beautiful from outside, but also beautiful inside.” Indeed, the Kayapõ culture mirrors this idea through how the view tattoos as a “social skin” (Tuner, 1980) — here, tattooing is “simultaneously the exteriorization of the interior which is simultaneously the interiorization of the exterior” (Gell, cited in Schildkrout, 321; Gros, 323). This implies that tattoos reveal an “inside which comes from the outside, which has been applied externally prior to being absorbed into the interior” (Gros, 323). As these women point out, goodness within is reflected in a *tajwa* without — as such, the *tajwa* becomes an exteriorization of the beauty that exists within them, becoming a physical manifestation of that *sutho* quality within.

But as we have discussed earlier, the *tajwa* is extremely gendered. In some cultures, tattoos are thought to be used in order to save them from abduction — Chin women’s facial tattoos in Burma, for example, were thought to deter abduction by Burmese kings, protecting ethnic purity (Baillkin, 37). However, that is definitely not the case here — our interlocutors spoke of the *tajwas* as enhancing their beauty. We asked whether the men in their tribes could get *tajwas* to look beautiful, but they refused immediately. “No. This is for the women, women wear *tajwas*.” “What if men want to look beautiful?” “This is not for men.”

We had our own hypotheses for this extreme gendering — for the Drung, for instance, the tattoo is a key element in the “processual construction of womanhood” and “a form of embodiment of this fertile mystical influence” (Gros, 329, 331). Our interlocutors did not point to these ideas, but rather saw them as a way of connecting with their childhood, with their friends. The beauty of having shared a tattoo even as they were separated after their marriages was something that they pointed towards, seeing it as a way of connecting with those they leave behind. In the very gendered context of having to leave one’s home behind after marriage, there is something very beautiful in the female connections that are etched into the skin.

This is not to say that men are not conceived as beautiful in the Kohli society. In fact, when we asked the women who the most beautiful person in the world was to them, they spoke about their husbands, their fathers, and their brothers. Nano said, “For me, my husband is the most beautiful person, because he takes care of me, he brings food in the house for me and my children.” Younger interview participants spoke of their fathers and their brothers as the most beautiful people they knew — “My father, because he gives me money, and because he brings food in the house.” When we asked one of our younger interlocutors whose names they’d like to tattoo on their arms, she shyly replied, “My brother’s ... he takes care of me.” These ideals of beauty that extend across good to encapsulate the act of care and giving, of family and kindness, present how beauty becomes more than just a mark on the skin — the *tajwa* encapsulates one’s ability to perform good deeds, to care.

Mending Marks of *Tajwas*:

Beyond the aspect of beautification, getting a *tajwa* can also be the beginning of a healing process for these Kolhi women, very much like the Malagasy-Nias-Dravidian tribes of the Malabar Coast, who also use tattoos for medicinal purposes (Ghosh 2020). If someone develops a cyst or swelling, they tattoo a circle around the affected area in hopes of stopping its spread — or better yet, healing it entirely. A similar circle is drawn on a bone that has an abnormal growth. A woman showed us 3 dots on the side of her nose, saying that these *tajwas* are believed to stop it from growing larger. Some women also had dotted markings on their temples to relieve chronic headaches.

We had observed in our literature review that belief in dark forces of evil eye and jealousy is common throughout several societies. *Nazar*, or evil eye is said to be the most harmful affliction one can get, and in Pakistan, it is believed that it can be caught even from one’s closest loved ones. It is to note here that *nazar* roughly translates to ‘vision’, or ‘to see’; the evil eye is not thought to arise from within the person themselves, but rather from how (or with what intentions) they are *seen* by others, a social, relational harm tied to others’ gazes, perceptions, or envy. In Tamil Nadu, *kollan* tattoos are done for protection against evil eye (2017). The women of Baiga and Kothari tribes also practice a similar tattoo to protect themselves and their marriages (Kanchan Paul 2019). Similarly, in Pakistan and India, a *nazar ka tika* is done. We saw this practice in the Kolhis too. Almost all Kolhi women had the tiny three dotted triangle shaped *tajwa*, for spiritual protection, believing they help ward off the evil eye or black magic, safeguarding themselves and their families.

Something which struck me while writing this was the clash of beliefs between the two communities: Meghwar and Kolhi. We noticed that, when talking to the Kolhi women, they

would seldom mention religion in their conversations or “show any signs of religiosity” to put it informally. Even when we asked about their tattoos having any connections to their religious beliefs, they waved it off without a second thought, as if it were not an option to even consider (they were pausing to actually consider and think about some questions which seemed... complicated or abnormal to think of in daily lives, e.g. does inner beauty matter, but didn't do so for this one). Only one woman admitted to wanting a cow as tattoo, that too only because she said it's our gayi mata, and didn't care to elaborate, even upon pressing. However, note that the above discussion of the belief in nazar and healing tattoos (both physically and spiritually) was mostly about the Kolhi women.

On the other hand, the Meghwar women of the city had a whole different outlook on both tattooing and spirituality. Firstly, the fact that they would gather every day at the mandir to recite bhajans and share teachings, putting to pause their chores, speaks volumes (at least to me) about their commitment to their beliefs. Secondly, they claimed to be very religious, not in an orthodox way of fulfilling the Hindu practices; they talked a lot about Sufism, love, peace, the teachings of Kabir Das and Bheem Rao Ambhedkar. Yet very few of them seemed to actually do rituals like tattooing to protect themselves from spiritual harm as the Kolhis did. In fact, most of them seemed very against the whole idea of tattooing, equating it with “practices of the less educated”. Maybe they had other practices than tattooing to keep away from evil eye. Maybe they had different beliefs about it. Maybe they did not believe in nazar altogether. Anyhow, this whole clash of beliefs was quite interesting: no apparent religious affections yet wanting spiritual protection from the Negative on one side, and active involvement in spirituality but no regards of its afflictions on the other. If we had more time and logistical (and societal) assistance to stay, we would have loved to explore this direction further.

Tajwas as Embodied Archives of Belonging:

A common pattern we noticed throughout our field visit was that tajwas were usually done by a close female relative: the mother, the khala (mother's sister), or the girl's own sister. However, in a few cases, we were told the tattoos were given by a saheli (friend), another girl, usually of the same age. That image alone, a child stitching permanent ink into another child's skin, was deeply striking. It felt intimate. We were reminded of how, when we were children, we would often wear matching clothes with our siblings, a practice especially common in Pakistan, where children of similar ages are dressed alike by their parents, often also adorned with similar jewellery. As we grew older and began forming friendships, we started buying matching items with our friends instead: same earrings, bags, bracelets, or rings.

But in the stories these women shared, the matching item was not just a necklace or a bracelet. It was not something detachable or disposable, something you could put away from your body, mind, and sight whenever you wished. It was a tattoo, a permanent mark on the skin. A new part of your body. And a part of your friend too. They exchanged these markings as a way of remembering each other. Each friend gave the other the same design. They said it was so they would never forget one another, so the memory of their friendship would live on through the tajwa, which, while it fades, never truly disappears. It takes decades to vanish completely, and

even then, a trace always remains, just like the trace of friendship and connection they once shared.

We believe that the *tajwas* exchanged between friends were meant to last longer than the friendships themselves. As many of the women told us, girls in their community were not married within the same village. Instead, they were married off to distant places, far from their natal homes. These tattoos were done before marriage, because once both girls were relocated, unlike in cities where we might call a friend when we miss them, these women didn't have mobile phones. They couldn't read or write. So, the tattoos became a form of non-verbal, visual communication. They served as souvenirs of childhood friendship, a physical record etched into the skin. Unless by rare coincidence they married into the same area, it was unlikely they would ever see one another again, even if they returned to their mother's village, the chances of a reunion were slim.

So, they looked at their tattoos when they missed each other. A girl would remember her friend, someone her own age, someone she trusted enough to allow to drive a needle into her skin. Sometimes dangerously close to sensitive areas like the eyes, but mostly across the full length of the forearm, usually in a large design made from dots.

This practice of tattooing the body in memory of a loved one is not new. "It is difficult to date the origins of memorial tattoos, but the practice of wearing tattoos to remember someone may be as old as tattooing itself. Because of the permanent nature of tattoos, they are the perfect vehicle for inscribing on the body a visible reminder of a loved one or an important kinsman" (DeMello, 2016). Across different cultures and historical moments, tattoos have served as physical markers of attachment, grief, loyalty, and remembrance.

In fact, the idea that tattoos carry meanings beyond self-expression, that they exist not just on the body but through the body as a social gesture, is well-documented in anthropological literature. For example, Holocaust survivors and their descendants have used tattoos to remember pain and survival. Alice Bloch's work explores this: she interviews people with tattoos referencing ancestors who lived through the Holocaust. Though some placed these tattoos where they would be visible to the public, they often described them as private, meant for personal remembrance, not display. In one instance, she describes how Adam, a survivor's son, walks her through all his tattoos except for the numbered one (which were tattooed in memory of Holocaust survivors), a moment of quiet omission that reveals how tattoos are bound up with grief, memory, and the unspeakable.

Similarly, Gentry and Alderman analyze tattoos in post-disaster New Orleans following Hurricane Katrina. Survivors used tattoos to memorialize people they had lost, or what they almost lost. The article argues that while spontaneous street memorials eventually disappear, tattoos offer a permanent and embodied archive of trauma and love, a transformation of personal pain into visible symbols of survival. Unlike the survivors, the tattoos of the women in Mithi were not about mourning. They were about joy, about fondness, about love, deep, loyal friendships. They got their tattoos not just for themselves, but by others, for others. A form of mutual inscription. A form of memory exchange.

Federica Manfredi's ethnographic work in central Italy, exploring tattoos commemorating death, and celebrating birth, offers a compelling framework for understanding how tattoos materialize relationships. Her research shows that tattoos often serve as embodied responses to major life transitions, such as the arrival of a child or the loss of a loved one. These marks, she argues, are not only emotional expressions but deeply social acts: the skin becomes a site where private memory and public meaning intersect. Drawing on Turner's (1980) idea of the skin as a social stage, Manfredi reveals how tattoos are both intimate and performative, personalized spiritual gestures and long-term investments in identity that speak to specific audiences.

Thinking with Manfredi's framework, the *tajwas* of the girls in Mithi can be understood as relational inscriptions: marks through which the self is constituted not in isolation but in connection, through embodied acts of trust, intimacy, and affection. As anthropologist Claude Lévi-Strauss (1969) famously suggested, tattoos represent the transformation of the human from a "raw" being into a "cooked" cultural one. The process of inscribing the skin is thus not just a bodily act, but a social one, one that makes us human in and through our relationships. This is reflected in the *tajwa* practices of the women in Mithi. While some tattoos may be done for beauty, it is rarely beauty for the self. Even when a woman wants to feel beautiful, it is in relation to how she appears to others. In this sense, many, if not all, tattoos in Mithi can be seen as being done not for the self, but through the self, for others. The only possible exception may be medicinal tattoos, which as told by them, are done to prevent or treat bodily ailments such as cysts. But even these exist within a shared body of local knowledge, shaped by communal belief.

In the case of the matching, commemorative tattoos exchanged between friends, the social dimension is especially vivid. These are not solitary decisions or private markings, they are made by others, for others, as mutual acts of care and remembrance. They are not just expressions of affection; they are inscriptions of memory in a context where few formal tools for preserving the social exist.

Situated at the cusp of marriage, an institution that routinely displaces women from their natal networks and redistributes them across distant geographies, these girls use tattoos as a way to hold on to each other. The act of tattooing becomes a form of social anchoring, a way to fix a relationship in place before it is dissolved by separation. This echoes what Bergh (2016) explores in her qualitative study on commemorative tattoos, where many respondents got tattoos to honor and remember loved ones who had passed away. These tattoos served as a form of non-verbal communication, reminders to the dead that they remain close, etched permanently onto the skin. Drawing on the concept of *pragmemes* (contextualized speech acts), Bergh suggests that getting a tattoo can function like a speech act: a meaningful gesture that communicates love, memory, and enduring connection. Tattoos, in this framework, are not just images, they are emotional acknowledgments that say, "you are with me." Seen in this light, the practice of young girls in Mithi giving each other matching tattoos before marriage, and then moving away without knowing whether they will ever meet again, is deeply resonant. Though their friends are not dead, the uncertainty of future reunion renders these relationships

fragile, suspended. In many ways, the tajwa becomes a preemptive memorial, etched in anticipation of absence, a way of saying goodbye without saying it.

Tajwaha are not just marks on the skin, they are about memory, connection, and holding on to people who might otherwise be lost. As the women in Mithi tell us, these tattoos are made before marriage, at a time when they know they might be sent far away, possibly never to see their friends again. In that sense, the tattoos are never just about the self, they are for others, through others. They become a way to carry someone with you when no other form of staying in touch exists. In places where letters aren't written and phones don't ring, a tattoo is enough. And maybe that's what makes tajwaha so powerful: they don't just speak to beauty or identity, but to longing, to love, to the act of remembering. Even when the friendship fades, even when the face of the friend begins to blur in memory, the mark remains, quiet, personal, and lasting.

Tajwaha as Signs of Love and Appreciation:

While talking to women from the Kolhi community, we observed that some women choose designs out of devotion, love or affection. A cow (*gayi mata* — Mother Cow) would be drawn on the arm as a symbol of religious reverence. Some would have their own names, or the names of their loved ones inked on their bodies, indicating platonic or romantic love. However, we learned that these signatures of romantic relationships can only be inked once the couple has undergone *Pakki Shaadi* — the final religious ritual of marriage.

It is a consensual agreement among various scholars across the fields of ethnography, cultural studies, and psychology, that the skin is a way of self-expression. Like body language, verbal linguistics, and facial expressions, the human skin is also capable of regulating, processing and communicating one's feelings. Especially in a region like South Asia, where there is a very evident lack of expressing one's deepest emotions through verbal communication, practical gestures and self-sacrificial acts are considered two prominent types of love languages (Sharif et al., 2023).

In the Kolhi women, we see the manifestation of Turner's (1980) concept of social skin in expression of several emotions generally perceived as the positive sentiments. One of such sentiments observed is the feeling of appreciation and admiration towards different aspects of life: a number of women admitted to wanting to or already having tattoos which they associate with things and humans they appreciate in their lives. For instance, two women said that they wished to get more tattoos of the things they just find beautiful to look at: peacocks, cows, green trees and other gifts of nature. "The most beautiful things," she said, "are peacocks—because they are very pretty—and cows, due to religious beliefs, as cows are also our *gayi mata* (mother)." Another one had a scorpion drawn on her forearm, saying that she "liked how it sits on her skin". We think it is really important here to emphasize on the distinction between appreciation of beauty and the desire to beautify oneself. Another woman wanted to get a cow tattoo specifically due to its religious association.

One young woman shyly shared how her husband's name was tattooed on her forearm by her *bhabhi* (sister-in-law) after the *pakki shaadi*, a gesture of love, fulfilling her husband's wish.

A lot of women mentioned that their “husband is the most beautiful in the whole world.” A lot of women had their own names inked on their skins, right below the elbow. One of them had her brother’s name on the same part, saying she loves him more than anyone else in the world. One of the younger girls also admitted that although she loves all her siblings very dearly, the first tattoos she’d like to get would be her name and her brother’s name, one on each arm.

One woman said she chose exactly where her *tajwa* was made, on her forehead, because she only liked the *chand tara*. We asked what beauty meant to her. “The moon, the stars, and the crops,” she answered. Some of them, who find this beauty worth appreciating, choose to ink it onto their skin.

When asked what they feel when they see their tattoos, one of the young kids replied with a smile, “I like them. They’re beautiful.” When asked which design she liked best, she responded, “The *tiko*—on my face. I like it.”

One woman told us that no one from outside had ever asked her about her *tajwas* until we did. “To me,” she said, “they’re beautiful. They’re a tradition (*reet/rawaj*), and I’ve liked them since I was a child.”

Interestingly, all these markings expressed affection exclusively for the men in their lives. We did not encounter any woman who has another girl’s name, such as a friend’s or a sister’s, inked on her skin. Maybe the art of tattooing felt more like a connection to female associates, as discussed under the previous heading, than the tattoo itself.

While doing our literature review post-visit, all these instances seemed to reinforce the ideas discussed in similar studies: one explored the motivations and symbolism of tattoos in the Philippines. The author concluded that many people today get tattoos to deal with emotional phases throughout their lives (Carvajal et al., 2025). This author also used Maslow’s Hierarchy of Needs as a theoretical framework to demonstrate that tattooing can reflect different psychological and social needs—such as belonging, esteem, and self-actualization. Another paper talked about the commemorative tattoos in Italy, seeing tattoos as tools to “think, deal, and process crucial life changes” (Manfredi, 2022). Citing the personal anecdote of one of the interviewees, the author suggested that tattoos can be seen as tools to elaborate the tragedy of death, as experienced by a “father who lost his daughter”.

Although both papers highlighted relatively negative situations like processing grief, death, and relationship losses, what makes the Kolhi women’s case distinct is that their tattoos seem to embody positive rather than painful emotions. We did not encounter any tattoos linked to grief, trauma, or loss. Instead, they served as expressions of love and appreciation—toward nature, animals, and people alike. For these women, the tattoos may be seen as tools to actualize the sentiment of love—to give an abstract emotion a physical form and make it a part of themselves. Just as Manfredi’s (2022) study showed how tattoos serve both celebrative and commemorative purposes in rites of passage, we also firsthand saw their role in showing appreciation to the aspects of life they are grateful for. While scholars often frame tattooing as a way to communicate values, social status, or shared cultural practices, in the Kolhi context,

tattoos appear to communicate more intimate emotions—personal bonds, affection, and admiration for the world around them. All these encounters suggest that body markings can be as good a vessel to channel positive and highly passionate emotions, as to the heavy ones.

One young woman told us that “children are really beautiful,” and that “the husband is the most beautiful in the whole world.”

During the same literature review, we came across an ethnographic quantitative study that set out to disprove Lawrence Stone’s claim that “affection was of secondary importance to more utilitarian ambitions throughout much of European history.” According to Jankowiak and Fischer (1992), Stone insisted that “if romantic love ever existed outside of Europe, it only arose among the non-western nation-states’ elite who had the time to cultivate an aesthetic appreciation for subjective experiences.” To test this, the authors conducted a qualitative analysis on 186 societies to determine whether romantic love had a place in them. Any indication of romance—be it in personal anecdotes, literature, folklore, or even stories of elopement—was counted as an indicator that love existed in that society. One of their criteria stood out to us: “If the ethnographer claimed that romantic love was not present, yet provided a folktale or an incident that demonstrated passionate involvement, his or her interpretation was rejected.” Interestingly, only two such contradictions appeared in their sample. One of them was Pakistan. We found this deeply unsettling. It’s hard not to question what kinds of places and people were chosen to represent a Pakistani society in that study. Because from what we witnessed firsthand— not among the urban elite, gender-progressive, or emotionally expressive households, but in underprivileged, devoid of emotionally rich vocabulary, low-literacy communities of a small desert town—love was alive. A woman inking herself for the love of her husband, in her own language and through her own tradition, tells us more about romantic devotion than any survey or textbook possibly could. How, then, can a society whose classical literature is rooted so deeply in the language of love and *ishq*—a society that has its own version Romeo and Juliet like *Sassi-Punnu* and *Sohni-Mahiwal* in every local language—be deemed romantically absent? Love is not just European. It’s not just elite. Love is human. And universal. And the Kolhi women of Mithi are living proof of that.

These women sang wedding songs laced with longing. They spoke of Umar Marvi with tenderness and pride. Their ideas of love may not follow the frameworks we’ve been taught to recognize, but they’re there, etched into skin, sewn into stories, and passed through generations like heirlooms of the heart.

Conclusion:

As we think of the future of *tajwas*, we must question the construction of tradition and its understanding as an ahistorical cultural existence. Tradition is deeply connected to the past but there is no “original form” that exists divorced from the processes of time and movement. Here, any form of tradition is reconstructed and neo-constructed — as such, original form as a concept is relative, not absolute (Zheng, 2012). When we set out on this research journey, we sought to document this “tradition” because we feared its death in the contemporary era. However, in our conversations with the women in Tharparkar, we realised that the tradition

would morph to incorporate urban symbols rather than fade away — as such, it would continue in a cyclical pattern of growth rather than die out. Here, innovation is a characteristic of tradition, wherein culture learns and grows with respect to the conversations it is having with the world around it — as Sami ideologies illustrate, this is a cumulative knowledge, open to change, incorporating generations of experiences, observations, and adaptations.

The art of tajwa-making has been practiced for generations, yet like many traditions facing the forces of globalization and cultural homogenization, its future feels uncertain, especially when viewed from the lens of a city like Karachi. There, the impact of modernity and the erosion of cultural distinctiveness is visible almost everywhere. It made us wonder: what lies ahead for tajwas? This tradition, carried by women largely untouched by the internet's hustle and the rapid pace of modern life, still thrives in spaces that appear to exist outside time. And yet, applying even the most basic logic drawn from urban experiences, we couldn't help but worry whether tajwas, too, might fade into the past. This fear was echoed in the limited literature we found, which suggested that the practice is at risk of dying. But as we engaged with women from the Kolhi and Meghwar communities, it became clear that the reality is far more layered. Their perspectives, at times conflicting, reveal not the disappearance of tajwas, but rather their transformation.

Among the Kolhi, particularly in the rural stretches of Tharparkar, elderly women still respond with joy when younger girls express interest in receiving tajwas. While they don't necessarily condemn those who opt out of the practice, some admitted to creating subtle pressures, encouraging their daughters in ways that made the ritual feel like an obligation. Interestingly, many women claimed the tradition was not declining at all. In fact, they believed it had become more visible. Some even pointed out that young women today have more tajwas than they did at the same age. To them, this was not a sign of loss but of evolution. They also spoke of a shift toward temporary forms, like sticker tattoos, suggesting that while the medium may change, the symbolic value remains intact.

In contrast, urban Meghwar women in Mithi viewed the decline of tajwa culture as directly linked to rising levels of education and literacy, a fear we had, that globalization and city trends would eventually reach even these relatively insulated communities. For them, tattoos increasingly seem outdated in the context of urban life. Some felt subtle pressure to let go of the tradition, not because they were judged outright, but because they were surrounded by women, especially those educated or living in cities, who had no tajwas themselves.

One woman, Tulsi, initially just our point of contact, but eventually a vocal presence in all conversations, seemed particularly resentful of the tradition. She would often answer questions on behalf of others, despite not being an interviewee herself. According to her, women in the past had more time; their lives revolved around housework and childbearing, so they sought ways to entertain themselves, like getting tattoos. Now, she argued, women are working, have access to phones, and can connect with the world beyond their immediate surroundings. In her eyes, they now have more freedom and less need for such customs.

But her argument felt shaky. Looking around the village, women's lives appeared largely unchanged: they still woke up early, worked on farms, cooked, cleaned, just as the generations before them had done. If time was limited now, it had always been so. Tulsi's claim that "women used to have time, and now they don't" didn't help us fully understand the evolving perception around tattoos.

What became more interesting was how women interpreted the change themselves. When we asked whether they felt judged by urban women for having tajwas, they confidently said no. They did not perceive any stigma. So then, why is it that some urban women in Mithi feel compelled to distance themselves from the practice? If there is no direct social pressure, are they projecting expectations onto themselves?

Meanwhile, rural women noted that more and more girls are choosing to get tajwas today. This divergence, between women of the same region, raises an important question: what happens when urban women begin to abandon the tradition while rural women embrace it more strongly? Will the practice splinter, surviving in isolated pockets but losing its broader cultural grounding? Or will this rural resurgence be enough to keep the tradition alive? The fate of tajwas, then, does not lie in a clear narrative of decline or survival. It lives in the contrast between perception and practice, between city and village, between the desire to preserve and the urge to move on.

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